

3.1.3 Area of study 2: Pop music

For the purpose of this specification, pop music is defined as popular mainstream music derived from and including a number of musical genres including rock, funk and R&B from 1960 to the present.

Named artists

- Stevie Wonder
- Joni Mitchell
- Muse
- Beyoncé
- Daft Punk
- Labrinth

Musical elements

The following table contains all the musical elements, for this area of study, that students must know and understand to answer questions in section A (Listening) and section C (Essay) of the exam. Marks will also be awarded for knowledge of other terms, if relevant to this area of study, in section C (Essay) of the exam.

Element type	Element
Melody	• riff • pitch bend • melisma, syllabic • hook • slide • glissando • ostinato • blue notes.
Harmony	• power chords • sus4 chords • chord extensions – secondary 7th, 9th, 11th, 13th • other complex chords eg half diminished 7th, added 6th • chord symbols eg C/E C⁷ C^ø and C⁺ • tonic and dominant pedal.
Tonality	• specific modes eg dorian, lydian • pentatonic • blues scale.
Structure	• intro/outro • middle 8 • bridge • breakdown • verse • chorus • instrumental • break • drum fill.
Sonority (Timbre)	• studio/technological effects eg reverb, panning • standard contemporary instrumental types eg electric guitar, synthesisers • drum kit components and techniques eg rim shot • vocal timbres eg falsetto, belt, rap • specific instrumental techniques eg slap bass • specific instrumental effects eg distortion.
Texture	• looping • layering • a cappella.

Element type	Element
Tempo, metre and rhythm	• bpm (beats per minute) • mm (metronome marking) • groove • backbeat • irregular metre.
Dynamics and articulation	• fade in/fade out.